

Bass & Counter-Melody Builder

Bass: four levels

Go up one level at a time. Stop when it sounds good. Simple often wins.

Level 1 — Roots

Play the chord's letter name on beat 1. (C chord → play C.)

Level 2 — Lock with the kick

Play the root, but copy the **kick drum's rhythm**. When bass and kick hit together, the groove feels tight.

Level 3 — Root + fifth or octave

Bounce between the root and the note five steps up (C → G), or the same note higher (low C → high C).

Level 4 — Walk to the next chord

On the last beat of the bar, step toward the next chord's root. Example, C going to G: C ... E – F – **G**.

Example (key of C, progression C – G – Am – F)

- **Level 1:** C | G | A | F — one long note per bar
- **Level 2:** C C . C (matches a Basic Rock kick)
- **Level 3:** C – G – C – G | G – D – G – D | A – E – A – E | F – C – F – C

Bass tips

- **Simpler under singing.** Busy bass is fine in the intro and between lines.
- **Low-note mud:** if chords and bass are both low, move the chords up an octave.

- **Pedal tone** (Level 2 trick): hold the home note in the bass while chords change on top. Creates tension.
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Counter-melody: two rules

A counter-melody is a second melody that fills the gaps in the main one.

1. **When the lead moves, the counter-melody holds or rests.**
2. **When the lead holds or rests, the counter-melody moves.**

Put it **higher or lower** than the lead and use a **different sound** (bells, pluck synth, guitar, strings).

A short counter-melody that repeats is a **riff**. Riffs make great intros.

Where could my counter-melody go?

- ☐ Intro riff
 - ☐ In the gaps between chorus lines
 - ☐ After each verse line
 - ☐ Answering the vocal hook (call and response)
 - ☐ Bridge or instrumental section
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In おんぷノート

The app keeps one score at a time, so each part gets its own score and its own PDF.

1. Save your current score as a PDF first.
2. Start a new score with a **bass clef**. Pick a bass-like playback sound.
3. Check each bass note against your chord chart. The note on beat 1 should usually be the chord's root.
4. Export the PDF (`S2-[title]-bass-v1.pdf`).
5. For the counter-melody: new score, treble clef, bright sound, export the PDF.

6. Hear everything together by playing each part into GarageBand, reading from your PDFs.

My bass level: 1 / 2 / 3 / 4 **My counter-melody sound:** _____